



RPI's Outdoor Programs & Rensselaer Outing Club

Caving Policies:

The intention of this document is to provide standardization of all indoor and outdoor caving programs that are conducted by Outdoor Programs (OP) Rensselaer and Outing Club (ROC) at Rensselaer Polytechnic Institute. Caving has the potential to be a dangerous activity. It is because of this inherent danger; the conduct of leaders and participants needs to be guided by accepted program standards. This document is designed to provide guidelines of conduct for caving trip leaders which are accepted by professional practitioners throughout the greater outdoor education and recreation industry.

The standards put forth in the document are created with leading industry practices, years of combined experience, and the organization's culture/legacy in high consideration.

This document is organized by Program Overview and Guiding Principles, Trip Leader Qualifications, Trips Classifications, Approved Gear List, Proper Documentation, and a Document Amendment History.

Program Overview and Guiding Principles:

Role of the Leaders:

- When facilitating a Caving trip, leadership needs to be established to monitor for unwarranted risk on the participants, leaders, equipment, and institution.
 - Leaderships are defined as:
 - Assistant Caving Leader (i.e Assistant Leader)
 - Caving Trip Leader (i.e. Trip Leader)
 - Assistant Vertical Caving Leader (i.e. Advanced Assistant Leader)
 - Vertical Caving Trip Leader (i.e. Advanced Trip Leader)

- Every caving trip must have a Caving Leader and an Assistant Caving Leader as a minimum requirement, or, in the case of a vertical caving trip, a Vertical Caving Leader and Assistant Vertical Caving Leader.
- All Trip Leaders will always prioritize risk management during the program.
- Depending on the difficulty of the trip, leadership is responsible for educating participants on important skills and pertinent information required to have a successful day.
- Leadership should take the time to seek adjustments for the needs of the participants.
- Trip Leaders should always act in a professional manner as a representative of the greater RPI and caving community.

Risk Management:

- The sport of caving contains elements of risk. Exposure to risk can be managed, but not eliminated from someone who engages in the sport of caving.
- Location, weather, exposure, wildlife, terrain, equipment, physical ability, health concerns, distractions, and more all contribute, but is not limited to, potential risks on a caving program.
- Many incidents/accidents are unforeseen and could be avoided with proper preparation. It is a major focus of a caving leader to anticipate these factors and provide protection from these risks to the best of their abilities.
- Proper documentation of accidents/incidents as well as post trip summaries (GRO reports) aid in the effort to anticipate possible unnecessary exposure to risk.

Etiquette:

- Proper etiquette is important to all who participate in caving so that access to these places can be maintained and effects on the natural environment can be minimized.
- Trip Leaders should be aware of the rules and expectations on the cavers at the trip location.
- Be aware of local laws and regulations before adding/removing hardware or fixed gear.
- Treat others with respect and dignity. Caving Leaders model respectful behavior in the hopes of promoting good habits for other cavers in their community.

Drugs and Alcohol Policy:

Those under the influence of a substance that alters their ability to follow directions or affects their independent decision making shall be removed from any ROC or OP caving program. This includes but is not limited to drugs, alcohol, medication, etc.

General Program Guidelines:

Horizontal Caving:

- Trip leaders must abide by the guiding principles mentioned above.
- All trips will follow local and state laws and regulations regarding their intended activity.
- Helmets must be worn in-cave.
- All caving trips must have a minimum of three people, including the Trip Leader and Assistant Leader.
- Participants should always remain under the supervision of trip leaders.
- The maximum ratio for participants to leaders is 8:2 on introductory trips and 6:2 on intermediate and advanced trips (or in accordance with the cave's regulations).
- Horizontal caving trips need to be announced a week before they start.
- All other ROC and OP Policies are to be followed in addition with Caving Policies.

Vertical Caving:

- Trip leaders must abide by the guiding principles mentioned above.
- All trips will follow local and state laws and regulations regarding their intended activity.
- Helmets must be worn in-cave or when in proximity of rigged ropes.
- Only vertical caving leaders and assistant vertical leaders can set rigging and build anchors.
- Ropes are to be rigged in accordance with the cave's regulations.
- All vertical caving trips must have a minimum of three people, including the Vertical Trip Leader and Assistant Vertical Leader.
- Participants should always remain under the supervision of trip leaders.
- The maximum ratio for participants to leader 6:2 on vertical trips (or in accordance with the cave's regulations).
- Vertical caving trips need to be announced a week before they start.
- All other ROC and OP Policies are to be followed in addition with Caving Policies.

Vertical Sessions:

Vertical leaders and assistant vertical leaders will host vertical practice sessions so that individuals may exercise their vertical skills in a controlled/educational environment. Participants of vertical caving trips will demonstrate knowledge of the vertical gear and competence in vertical skills within a session before participating in a vertical caving trip with ROC or OP.

These training sessions will be closed sessions open only to approved individuals.

Rules:

- Only Vertical Caving leaders and Outdoor Programs professional staff will be allowed to rig and de-rig ropes
- Ropes should be rigged to lower via an MMO (Munter-Mule Overhand) or equivalent (in the case of pickoffs, the rope should be rigged via a tied off super munter hitch)
- Each leader/assistant leader will supervise a maximum of 1 rope in use at a time.
- Helmets shall be worn while in the vicinity of a rigged rope.

- No more than one person can be on the rope at a time except for practicing pickoffs

Caving Trip Leader Qualifications:

Assistant Caving Leader:

An Assistant Leader is an individual that has a developed understanding of essential caving skills. They are learning the role of Caving Leader, but do not have enough experience or knowledge to assume the role of a leader. An Assistant Leader helps the Trip Leader in all trip-leading responsibilities as well as takes the time to further develop their knowledge base.

To become an Assistant Caving Leader, one must have:

- Outdoor Wilderness Leadership Course
- Wilderness First Aid certification
- CPR Certification
- Has been a participant on at least one ROC or OP caving trip.
- Orientation to Cave Rescue (OCR) Course through the National Cave Rescue Commission (NCRC)
- An understanding of OP and ROC General and Caving Policies.

Caving Trip Leader:

A Caving Trip Leader assumes the role of lead instructor of the caving program. They are responsible for creating the appropriate atmosphere, managing risk, providing instruction/details, organization and all aspects of the caving trip. It is important that the person in this role is well suited to the responsibilities they are assuming.

To become a Caving Trip Leader, one must have:

- All the qualifications required for an Assistant Caving Leader
- Orientation to Cave Rescue (OCR) Course through the National Cave Rescue Commission (NCRC)
- Approval by the current ECOMM and then OP professional staff
- Demonstrated greater competencies of caving concepts and practices.
- Have participated in at least two ROC or OP Caving Programs as an Assistant Leader.

Assistant Vertical Caving Leader:

An Assistant Vertical Leader is an individual who has a developed understanding of essential caving skills. They are learning the role of Vertical Caving Leader, but do not have enough

experience or knowledge to assume the role of a Vertical Cave leader. An Assistant Vertical Leader helps the Trip Leader in all trips leading responsibilities as well as takes the time to further develop their knowledge base.

To become an Assistant Vertical Leader for caving programs, one must have:

- All the qualifications required for a Caving Trip Leader
- Have participated in at least one ROC or OP Vertical Caving Programs
- Have knowledge and understanding of the techniques taught in a Small Party Assisted Rescue (SPAR) course though the NCRC (or an equivalent)
- Knowledge of anchor systems, ascension systems, rappelling techniques, and cave rescue techniques

Vertical Caving Trip Leader:

A Vertical Caving Trip Leader assumes the role of lead instructor of the vertical caving program. They are responsible for creating the appropriate atmosphere, managing risk, providing instruction/details, and organizing the caving trip. It is important that the person in this role is well tailored to the responsibilities they are assuming.

To become a Vertical Caving Trip Leader, one must have:

- All the qualifications required for a Caving Leader
- Have participated in at least two ROC or OP Vertical Caving Programs
- Has passed the Small Party Assisted Rescue (SPAR) course though the NCRC (or an equivalent)
- Knowledge of anchor systems, ascension systems, rappelling techniques, and cave rescue techniques.
- Approval by the current ECOMM and then OP professional staff.

Trip Classifications:

Introductory:

These trips are designed to introduce cavers to the sport of caving. Caves should be horizontal, generally dry, and have limited required crawl sections. These trips should last up to three hours.

Time is spent teaching basic skills and caving knowledge. Topics that are normally covered are cave conservation, caving technique, leave-no-trace, etc. Approaches should be kept short, and the chosen cave is appropriate for beginner cavers.

Intermediate:

Trips in this designation contain characteristics that would not be appropriate for a beginner caver. Intermediate caves may be wet, contain required crawling, and last up to four hours.

Advanced:

Advanced Caving Trips are reserved for the highest level of horizontal a caving trip allowed by RPI programs and its scope of practice. Special attention needs to be given to the details of an Advanced trip before it is approved. An advanced cave may include lots of wet passages, extensive crawling or scrambling, and may last over four hours. Only participants with extensive experience in caving should participate in an Advanced trip.

Vertical:

Vertical Caving Trips are trips which contain vertical sections that require ascending and descending on a rope. Only Vertical Trip Leaders are permitted to lead Vertical Trips. A vertical cave may contain wet passages, extensive crawling or scrambling, vertical passages (which requires the use of rope), and last over four hours. Only participants who have attended a Vertical Session and demonstrated participant required skills as outlined below may participate in a Vertical Trip.

Participant Required Skills (Taken from NCRC SPAR student preparation guide):

A participant must have the ability (as per the leader's discretion) to perform the following within 25 minutes:

- Start with gear off and on the ground
- Properly don gear (harness and PPE) and conduct a personal safety check
- Approach and begin ascending the rope with the appropriate commands
- Continue ascending the rope and conduct a knot pass
- Resume ascending until reaching a satisfactory height specified by the leader prior to the test
- Conduct a change-over, with a rappel safety check
- Descend past the knot
- Stop just above the ground and demonstrate an appropriate hard lock-off of the descent control device (DCD)
- Change-over to ascending and down-climb to the ground
- Get off the rope and exit the fall zone before calling "off rope"

Approved Gear List

Personal gear is the responsibility of the individual who is participating in the caving program. If they need to borrow gear from the Gear Room, it is up to them to acquire the gear according to Gear Room policies. Group gear will be the responsibility of the trip's leadership and will be borrowed under their names.

Personal/Individual Packing Lists:

- Helmet
- Three independent sources of caving appropriate light
- Water
- Snacks
- Layers (durable, non-cotton)
- Medications
- Gloves
- Knee pads (recommended)
- Trash bag
- Change of clothes

Group Gear:

- Cave pack
- Cave maps (in a ziploc or otherwise waterproofed)
- Palmer furnace
- First aid kit
- Extra batteries
- Webbing
- Carabiners
- Extra food
- Extra water

Personal Vertical Gear:

- All horizontal personal items, plus
- Caving harness
- Descent device (standard or micro rack, bobbin, etc.) with locking carabiner or quicklink
- Chest ascender and chest harness
- Hand ascender
- Foot loop with carabiner (locking or non-locking)
- Cow's tail with two locking carabiners (long end connected to hand ascender and short free end)

Group Vertical Gear:

- All horizontal group items, plus
- Static rope (long enough for any drops encountered within the cave)
- Extra webbing/cordage
- Anchor building material
- Locking carabiners (for anchor plus 4 additional to be taken in-cave)
- 2 prusik cords
- SPAR Kit (a caver appropriate assortment of extra carabiners, pulleys, rope grabs, etc)

Proper Trip Planning and Documentation:

Pre-Trip Preparations:

All trips that leave campus need to have in place specific documents in place to run correctly. It is important to have these documents in place for the protection of the participants, leaders, and organization. In not doing so, the leaders of those trips open themselves to becoming liable in the case of an incident/accident.

Permits:

It is unlawful for cavers to access certain lands or caves without the possession of a granted permit. Federal, state, or local agencies may require permits to conduct caving on land that is under their jurisdiction. There is the chance that permission is required on multiple levels of these agencies and could complicate the permitting process. It is the responsibility of the individuals who are facilitating the caving program to make sure they are permitted to use the land in the intended way.

Waivers:

Every individual who is involved in an ROC or OP caving program needs to have a RPI Outdoor Programs Assumption of Risk Informed Consent Release on file before the start of the program. These waivers allow the participant to make an informed decision about whether they want to participate in the program. Waivers highlight the foreseeable risks that are related to the activity and outline the anticipated conduct and expectations of participants. Make sure that they are filled out to completion and that if the caver is under 18 years of age, that they have a parent's signature as well.

Fees:

If fees are to be collected for any means, students are to fill out a Change/Payment/Adjustment sheet and submit them to OP.

Outdoor Trip Plan:

A completed Outdoor Trip Plan must be submitted to the shared Outdoor Programs' Trip Sheet folder a week before the expected departure date. In the event of changes or cancellations/additions, an updated OTP must be on file before the trip departs. By not doing so, the leaders of the trip will be asked to meet with Outdoor Programs staff, a member/members of ECOMM, and the chair of said activity for review and course of action moving forward.

"Leave nothing but footprints, take nothing but pictures, and kill nothing but time" - NSS Motto